



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 05/19/2026	Entry: 01
Description	Severe disruption of clinic's business operations due to a malicious phishing email containing ransomware
Tool(s) used	None.
The 5 W's	A small U.S. health care clinic specializing in delivering primary-care services experienced a security incident on a Tuesday morning, at approximately 9:00 a.m. Several employees reported that they were unable to use their computers to access files like medical records. Business operations shut down because employees were unable to access the files and software needed to do their job. Additionally, employees also reported that a ransom note was displayed on their computers. The ransom note stated that all the company's files were encrypted by an organized group of unethical hackers who are known to target organizations in healthcare and transportation industries. In exchange for restoring access to the encrypted files, the ransom note demanded a large sum of money in exchange for the decryption key. The attackers were able to gain access into the company's network by using targeted phishing emails, which were sent to several employees of the company. The phishing emails contained

	a malicious attachment that installed malware on the employee's computer once it was downloaded. Once the attackers gained access, they deployed their ransomware, which encrypted critical files. The company was unable to access critical patient data, causing major disruptions in their business operations. The company was forced to shut down their computer systems and contact several organizations to report the incident and receive technical assistance.
Additional notes	Due to a lack of security awareness several targeted employees willingly downloaded the malicious file attached without confirming the origin of the email thus allowing the threat actors to gain access to the network and sabotage daily operations and risking sensitive patient data with ransomware. We would have to review the logs and employees that were affected, check their privilege levels and find similarities to determine why and how these individuals were chosen as targets. In addition the employees reported the ransom note displayed on their computers. The employees did not specify whether these were physical paper notes or a pop-up prompt within the system.

Date: 05/22/2026.	Entry: 02
Description	A suspicious password-protected spreadsheet attachment was downloaded and opened by an employee. After the file was opened, multiple unauthorized executable files were created on the employee's computer. A SHA256 hash was used to investigate the file in VirusTotal and identify related indicators of

	compromise.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal Pyramid of Pain SHA256 file hash analysis
The 5 W's	● Who: The incident appears to have been caused by an external threat actor who sent a malicious email attachment to an employee. The malware associated with the hash has been linked to Flagpro/BlackTech activity. ● What : An employee received an email with a password-protected spreadsheet attachment. The email included the password needed to open the file. After the employee downloaded and opened the spreadsheet, a malicious payload executed and multiple unauthorized executable files were created on the employee's computer. An intrusion detection system later detected the suspicious executable files and alerted the SOC. ● When : The incident occurred between 1:11 p.m. and 1:20 p.m. The employee received the email at 1:11 p.m., downloaded and opened the file at 1:13 p.m., unauthorized executable files were created at 1:15 p.m., and the IDS alert was triggered at 1:20 p.m. ● Where: The incident happened on an employee's computer within the financial services company's environment. ● Why : The incident happened because the employee opened a malicious password-protected spreadsheet attachment from an email. The password protection may have helped the attachment avoid detection by automated scanning tools. Once opened, the file executed a malicious payload.
Additional notes	The SHA256 hash investigated was:

	54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b This file should be treated as malicious based on the VirusTotal investigation and the behavior described in the alert. Related IoCs included hash values, a suspicious domain, IP addresses, host artifacts, and TTPs such as phishing, password-protected attachment delivery, user execution, and malware payload execution. The incident should be escalated for containment, endpoint isolation, malware removal, and further investigation of any network connections or additional affected hosts.
--	--

Date: 05/22/2026	Entry: 03
Description	Reviewed phishing alert ticket A-2703 involving a possible malware download from an email attachment. The email was sent to the HR mailbox and contained a suspicious attachment named bfsvc.exe . The attachment's SHA256 hash was listed as known malicious.
Tool(s) used	Phishing incident response playbook Alert ticket VirusTotal / file hash analysis Pyramid of Pain reference
The 5 W's	• Who: The incident appears to have been caused by an external threat actor impersonating a job applicant named "Clyde West" and sending a

	malicious email attachment to the company's HR mailbox. • What: A phishing email was sent to hr@inergy.com with the subject line Re: Infrastructure Egnieer role. The message claimed to include a resume and cover letter, but the attachment was an executable file named bfsvc.exe. The ticket also included a known malicious SHA256 hash associated with the file. • When: The email was sent on Wednesday, July 20, 2022 at 09:30:14 AM • Where: The incident occurred in the company email environment, specifically involving the HR mailbox at hr@inergy.com. The alert source was listed as SERVER-MAIL. • Why: The threat actor likely attempted to trick HR into opening a malicious attachment by disguising it as a resume and cover letter for an engineering role. The use of a password-protected file and a provided password may have been intended to make the email appear legitimate or bypass security scanning.
Additional notes	This alert should be escalated to a level-two SOC analyst because the attachment is present and its hash is known malicious. The email also contains several phishing indicators, including spelling and grammar issues, a suspicious sender address, and an executable attachment pretending to be job application materials. The playbook directs analysts to escalate when a link or attachment is confirmed malicious.

Date: 05/22/2026	Entry: 04
Description	Reviewed the final incident report for a previous data breach involving the

	company's e-commerce web application. The breach exposed customer personally identifiable information and financial information after an attacker exploited a forced browsing vulnerability in purchase confirmation pages.
Tool(s) used	Final incident report Web application access logs Incident handler's journal
The 5 W's	• Who: The incident was caused by an external attacker who exploited a vulnerability in the company's e-commerce web application. The attacker later contacted the company by email and demanded cryptocurrency payment in exchange for not publicly releasing the stolen customer data. • What: The attacker performed a forced browsing attack by modifying the order number in the URL of a purchase confirmation page. This allowed the attacker to access customer purchase confirmation pages that should not have been publicly accessible. As a result, customer PII and financial information were exposed and exfiltrated. Approximately 50,000 customer records were affected. • When: The first known contact from the attacker occurred on December 22, 2022, at approximately 3:13 p.m. PT, when an employee received an extortion email. The incident was escalated on December 28, 2022, after the attacker sent a second email containing a sample of stolen customer data and increased the ransom demand. The final report identifies the security incident date as December 28, 2022, at 7:20 p.m. PT. • Where The incident occurred in the company's e-commerce web application. Specifically, the vulnerability was found in the purchase confirmation page URL structure, where customer order numbers could be modified to access other customers' transaction data.

	• Why: The incident happened because the e-commerce web application did not properly restrict access to customer purchase confirmation pages. The application allowed an attacker to modify order numbers in the URL and access unauthorized customer transaction records. This indicates missing or insufficient access controls, authorization checks, and URL allowlisting.
Additional notes	he company responded by investigating the incident, reviewing web application access logs, identifying the root cause, disclosing the breach to customers, and offering free identity protection services to affected users. Future prevention measures should include routine vulnerability scanning, penetration testing, stronger access control, URL allowlisting, and ensuring that only authenticated and authorized users can access customer content. Since e-commerce accounts for a major portion of company sales, securing web application workflows should be treated as a high priority.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • What happened?

	• When did the incident occur? • Where did the incident happen? • Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who caused the incident? • What happened? • When did the incident occur? • Where did the incident happen? • Why did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: Some activities were challenging because I had to slow down and separate similar concepts, such as IDS vs. IPS, phishing vs. malware, and data theft vs. forced browsing. It was also challenging to organize the 5 W's clearly without adding too much unnecessary information. However, each activity helped me think more like a SOC analyst. My understanding has changed because I now see incident response as a structured process instead of just reacting to alerts. I learned that analysts must gather evidence, identify indicators of compromise, document timelines, and decide whether an alert should be escalated. I also understand that containment and prevention depend on accurate investigation. One of the tools I enjoyed most was VirusTotal because it helped connect file hashes, malware behavior, domains, and other indicators of compromise into one investigation. I also liked the Pyramid of Pain because it showed me that not all indicators are equally valuable. This helped me understand how defenders can make attacks harder to repeat.